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TOWNSHIP OF MAPLEWOOD, NEW JERSEY

DEPARTMENT OF FINANCE & REVENUE • OFFICE OF THE TAX COLLECTOR & ASSESSOR

Comprehensive Municipal Property Tax & Assessment Manual

An authoritative reference guide for residential property owners, homebuyers, and municipal taxpayers detailing annual residential mill rates, bi-monthly and quarterly billing cycles, late penalty enforcement, assessment appeal procedures, and estimated tax schedules categorized by square footage and building unit classifications.

Part I: Valuation & Mill Rates

Certified residential mill rate of 0.0094523, triennial reassessment cycles, and Essex County tax equalization.

Part II: Due Dates & Billing

Strict bi-monthly payment schedule, 10-day statutory grace period, and 1.25% monthly delinquency interest.

Part III: Size-Based Matrix

Official tax estimation schedules across 4 square-footage tiers for single-family homes and duplex dwellings.

STATUTORY PROPERTY TAX NOTICE:

Under N.J.S.A. 54:4-64, failure to receive a property tax bill does not relieve the owner of the obligation to pay taxes or interest accrued. All taxes are payable to the Township of Maplewood.

TAX ADMINISTRATION OFFICES:

Maplewood Town Hall • Revenue & Taxation
574 Valley Street, Maplewood, NJ 07040
Tax Collector: (973) 762-8120 Ext. 2500 | Tax Assessor: Ext. 2300
Hours: Monday to Friday: 8:30 AM – 4:30 PM

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Effective Tax Year: 2026–2027 Municipal Tax Cycle
Mill Rate Baseline: 0.0094523 (Residential Certified)

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Chapter 1: The Maplewood Property Assessment & Mill Rate Framework

The Township of Maplewood Department of Finance and Office of the Tax Assessor administer the valuation of all real estate within municipal borders in accordance with the **New Jersey Constitution (Uniform Assessment Clause)** and **N.J.S.A. 54:4 et seq.**

HOW PROPERTY TAXES ARE DETERMINED

A property's total municipal tax levy is calculated by multiplying its official certified assessed valuation by the combined municipal, county, and school tax rate. For the 2026 fiscal year, the Township Committee certified the combined residential tax rate at:

2026 Certified Residential Mill Rate

0.0094523

Equivalent to **$0.94523 per $100 of assessed property value**, or **$9.4523 per $1,000 of assessment**.

Statutory Tax Revenue Allocation

- **Local School District (48%):** Public K–12 education.
- **Municipal Government (34%):** Police, fire, DPW, roads, parks.
- **Essex County Administration (18%):** County roads and open space.

ASSESSMENT VS. MARKET VALUE EQUALIZATION

Maplewood conducts continuous sales-ratio analyses supervised by the Essex County Board of Taxation. A property's assessed value reflects its true market value as established during the last municipal-wide revaluation, updated annually by the Essex County Equalization Ratio.

ANNUAL POSTCARD ASSESSMENT NOTICE: On or before February 1 of each tax year, every property owner receives a state-mandated assessment postcard (Form Notice of Assessment). This card reflects the current taxable assessment of the land, building improvements, and total assessment.

Chapter 2: Property Tax Due Dates & Bi-Monthly Billing Schedule

Pursuant to New Jersey statutory law (N.J.S.A. 54:4-66) and Maplewood Township Code Chapter 231, municipal property taxes are billed across mandatory scheduled quarterly instalments, with optional bi-monthly reconciliation cycles:

INSTALMENT PERIOD	STATUTORY DUE DATE	GRACE PERIOD EXPIRATION	BILLING DESCRIPTION & STATUS
Period 1 (Jan/Feb)	**February 1**	February 10	Interim Billing (Based on prior year levy)
Period 2 (Mar/Apr)	**April 1**	April 10	Interim Billing (Spring instalment)
Period 3 (May/Jun)	**June 1**	June 10	Final Billing (Reconciled with municipal budget)
Period 4 (Jul/Aug)	**August 1**	August 10	Final Billing (Summer instalment)
Period 5 (Sep/Oct)	**October 1**	October 10	Final Billing (Fall instalment)
Period 6 (Nov/Dec)	**December 1**	December 10	Final Reconciliation & Year-End Closing

THE STATUTORY 10-DAY GRACE PERIOD

The Township provides a **statutory 10-calendar-day grace period**. Tax payments must be received in the Tax Collector's office on or before the 10th of the due month. If the 10th falls on a weekend or municipal holiday, payments are accepted on the next business day without penalty.

STRICT POSTMARK WARNING (N.J.S.A. 54:4-67):
Under New Jersey statutory law, **POSTMARKS ARE NOT ACCEPTED** as proof of timely payment. Payments must be physically received by the Tax Collector or deposited into the Town Hall 24/7 Drop Box before 4:30 PM on the grace period cutoff date.

DELINQUENCY INTEREST & PENALTIES

If payment is not received by the 10th day of the due month, interest is charged retroactive to the original due date at statutory rates:

- **8% per annum** on the first $1,500.00 of delinquency.
- **18% per annum** on any amount in excess of $1,500.00.
- A **6% year-end penalty** is charged on any delinquent balance in excess of $10,000 remaining unpaid on December 31.

Chapter 3: Estimated Property Tax Matrix by Size & Building Classification

Pursuant to municipal tax assessment valuation standards, property tax obligations reflect the certified assessed valuation of land and improvements, categorized across standard residential square footage brackets for **Single-Family Detached** and **Two-Family Residential** classifications:

FINISHED LIVING AREA	SINGLE-FAMILY DETACHED (SINGLE UNIT)	TWO-FAMILY RESIDENTIAL (DUPLEX)
Tier 1: 0 – 1,000 sq ft *(Starter Cottage / Bungalow)*	• Estimated Assessed Value: **$320,000 – $410,000** • Annual Estimated Tax: **$3,024 – $3,875** • Bi-Monthly Instalment: **~$504 – $646**	• Estimated Assessed Value: **$380,000 – $480,000** • Annual Estimated Tax: **$3,592 – $4,537** • Bi-Monthly Instalment: **~$598 – $756**
Tier 2: 1,000 – 2,000 sq ft *(Classic Colonial / Cape Cod)*	• Estimated Assessed Value: **$450,000 – $620,000** • Annual Estimated Tax: **$4,253 – $5,860** • Bi-Monthly Instalment: **~$708 – $976**	• Estimated Assessed Value: **$520,000 – $710,000** • Annual Estimated Tax: **$4,915 – $6,711** • Bi-Monthly Instalment: **~$819 – $1,118**
Tier 3: 2,000 – 3,000 sq ft *(Executive Victorian / Tudor)*	• Estimated Assessed Value: **$680,000 – $920,000** • Annual Estimated Tax: **$6,427 – $8,696** • Bi-Monthly Instalment: **~$1,071 – $1,449**	• Estimated Assessed Value: **$780,000 – $1,050,000** • Annual Estimated Tax: **$7,372 – $9,925** • Bi-Monthly Instalment: **~$1,228 – $1,654**
Tier 4: 3,000+ sq ft *(Estate Residence / Large Duplex)*	• Estimated Assessed Value: **$980,000 – $1,550,000+** • Annual Estimated Tax: **$9,263 – $14,651+** • Bi-Monthly Instalment: **~$1,544 – $2,442+**	• Estimated Assessed Value: **$1,120,000 – $1,780,000+** • Annual Estimated Tax: **$10,586 – $16,825+** • Bi-Monthly Instalment: **~$1,764 – $2,804+**

ESTIMATION METHODOLOGY NOTE: Figures are calculated using the 2026 certified mill rate ($0.0094523). Actual tax bills reflect specific lot dimensions, neighborhood valuation zones (e.g., Prospect vs. Boyden Heights), architectural condition, and recent building permits (e.g., renovated kitchens or finished basements).

Chapter 4: Authorized Payment Methods & Senior / Veteran Tax Relief

The Township provides four secure payment channels for paying property tax bills:

Online Banking & Web Portal

Pay via your financial institution's online bill payment service (Payee: *Township of Maplewood - Property Taxes*). Enter your **19-digit Tax Account / Roll Number**. Payments may also be made on `maplewoodnj.gov` via e-check ($1.95 fee) or credit card (2.95% fee).

Pre-Authorized Payment (PAP) Debit Plans

Enroll in Maplewood's automated direct debit program (zero bank transaction fees). Choose from three options:
• **10-Month Equalized Plan:** Debited on the 1st of each month (January through October).
• **12-Month Continuous Plan:** Debited on the 15th of each month year-round.
• **Due-Date Debit Plan:** Debited automatically on the 4 statutory quarterly due dates (Feb 1, May 1, Aug 1, Nov 1).

In-Person Cashier & 24/7 Town Hall Secure Drop Box

Payments can be delivered in person at the Tax Collector's cashier window at Maplewood Town Hall (574 Valley Street) during business hours (Mon–Fri 8:30 AM – 4:30 PM). A **24/7 Secure Drop Box** is located at the Park Road side entrance of Town Hall. Envelopes deposited before 4:30 PM on grace period cutoff dates are credited same day.

STATE & MUNICIPAL PROPERTY TAX RELIEF PROGRAMS

RELIEF PROGRAM	ELIGIBILITY CRITERIA	BENEFIT DESCRIPTION
Senior Freeze (Property Tax Reimbursement)	Age 65+ or receiving SSDI benefits; continuous NJ residency for 10+ years; household income under state limits.	Reimburses the difference between baseline year property tax and current year bill.
ANCHOR Program (Affordable Communities)	Homeowners and tenants residing in Maplewood on October 1; gross household income under $250,000.	Direct state tax relief credit up to $1,750 applied directly or mailed via state check.
Veteran & Surviving Spouse Deduction	Honorably discharged veteran of US Armed Forces or unremarried surviving spouse; NJ resident.	Annual statutory deduction of $250.00 subtracted directly from property tax levy.

Chapter 5: Municipal Water & Sewer Utility Billing, Tiers & Leak Diagnostics

Municipal water and sanitary sewer services are billed bi-monthly through the Maplewood Water Utility Division. Residential utility billing follows a transparent two-part rate structure:

1. Fixed Infrastructure Base Charge

- Standard 5/8" residential meter: **$32.50 bi-monthly base charge**.
- Dedicated capital funding for water main maintenance, booster pumping stations, smart meter upkeep, and 24/7 emergency fire hydrant flow readiness regardless of consumption.

2. Volumetric Consumption Tiers & Sewer Fee

- **Tier 1 (0 to 15,000 gallons): $4.20 per 1,000 gallons**.
- **Tier 2 (Over 15,000 gallons): $5.85 per 1,000 gallons**.
- **Sanitary Sewer Surcharge:** Calculated at **85% of metered water consumption** to fund regional wastewater treatment authority facilities.

HIGH CONSUMPTION BILLING DIAGNOSTICS & PRIMARY ROOT CAUSES

COMMON CAUSE	OPERATIONAL NATURE & WATER LOSS VOLUME	INSPECTION & REMEDIATION SOP
Silent Toilet Flapper Leak *(Cause of 80% of Spikes)*	Worn or misaligned rubber flapper valve allows water to continuously siphon into bowl. Can silently lose **200 gallons per day** (over **6,000 gallons / ~$35 per bi-monthly cycle**) with zero audible running sound.	Perform Food Coloring Dye Test. Replace rubber flapper valve ($6 hardware repair).
Irrigation Valve / Pipe Faults	Freeze cracked lawn irrigation lines or stuck solenoid zone valves cycling undetected overnight.	Isolate dedicated sprinkler shutoff valve and inspect yard for soft, saturated ground.
Water Softener Stuck in Backwash	Faulty mechanical float timer causes continuous regeneration drainage cycle discharging directly into sewer line.	Bypass water softener unit and inspect drain hose for continuous water discharge.

STEP-BY-STEP RESIDENT SELF-AUDIT LEAK TEST PROTOCOL

Smart AMI Meter Low-Flow Dial Check

1. Ensure all faucets, hoses, showers, dishwashers, and ice makers are completely turned off.
2. Locate water meter in basement or utility closet. Observe the dial's **Low-Flow Indicator** (small red/black triangle or spinning star).
3. If the indicator moves or spins even fractionally while all fixtures are off, an active pressurized leak is present on private plumbing.

The 15-Minute Toilet Dye Test

1. Remove the toilet tank lid and place **4 to 5 drops of dark food coloring** directly into the upper tank.
2. Do not flush the toilet. Wait strictly 15 minutes.
3. If colored water seeps into the toilet bowl, the tank flapper or flush valve seal is defective and must be cleaned or replaced.

HIGH CONSUMPTION DISPUTES & CERTIFIED BENCH METER TESTING:
Residents disputing consumption bills can request an hourly AMI smart usage audit by calling Water Billing at **(973) 762-8120 Ext. 215** or submitting a 311 audit request at `maplewoodnj.gov/services/request`. If an unresolved dispute persists, the resident may request physical bench testing under American Water Works Association (AWWA) standards ($50 deposit fee; if the meter over-registers by >1.5%, the $50 deposit is 100% refunded and the utility bill is retroactively credited).

Chapter 6: Assessment Appeals, Delinquencies & Tax Directory

HOW TO FILE AN ASSESSMENT APPEAL (COUNTY TAX BOARD)

Property owners who believe their property is assessed unfairly relative to true market value have the statutory right to file an appeal with the **Essex County Board of Taxation**:

ANNUAL STATUTORY FILING DEADLINE: APRIL 1
Under N.J.S.A. 54:3-21, tax appeals must be received by the Essex County Tax Board on or before **April 1 of the tax year**. Appeals filed after April 1 cannot be heard by law. If the total assessed value exceeds $1,000,000, direct appeal to the New Jersey State Tax Court is permitted.

Evidence Standard: Taxpayers must present recent (prior 12 months) certified comparable sales of similar properties within Maplewood. Real estate listings and neighborhood tax bill comparisons are not admissible before the Board. All municipal taxes and utility charges must be paid current to date to prosecute an appeal.

DELINQUENCY POLICIES, PENALTY STRUCTURES & TAX SALE LIENS

Retroactive Statutory Interest (N.J.S.A. 54:4-67)
- **8% per annum** on the first $1,500.00 of delinquency.
- **18% per annum** on amounts in excess of $1,500.00.
- **Retroactivity Rule:** If unpaid by the 10th of the due month, interest is calculated retroactively from the 1st of the due month.
- **6% Year-End Penalty:** Applied to delinquent balances exceeding $10,000 on December 31.

Municipal Tax Sale Lien Enforcement
- Pursuant to N.J.S.A. 54:5-19, properties with unpaid property taxes, water utility charges, or municipal assessments delinquent for more than **one calendar year** are subject to the annual **Township Tax Sale**.
- Tax sale liens accrue statutory penalties and can lead to judicial foreclosure if not redeemed within statutory periods.

DEPARTMENTAL DIRECTORY & MUNICIPAL TAX ADMINISTRATION DESK

DEPARTMENT / MUNICIPAL OFFICE	TELEPHONE & EXTENSION	OFFICIAL EMAIL ADDRESS	OFFICE HOURS & LOCATION
Office of the Tax Collector	(973) 762-8120 Ext. 2500	taxcollector@maplewoodnj.gov	Mon–Fri 8:30 AM – 4:30 PM • Town Hall
Office of the Tax Assessor	(973) 762-8120 Ext. 2300	taxassessor@maplewoodnj.gov	Mon–Fri 8:30 AM – 4:30 PM • Town Hall
Water & Sewer Utility Billing Desk	(973) 762-8120 Ext. 215	waterbilling@maplewoodnj.gov	Mon–Fri 8:30 AM – 4:30 PM • Town Hall
Finance Department & Treasurer	(973) 762-8120 Ext. 2100	finance@maplewoodnj.gov	Mon–Fri 8:30 AM – 4:30 PM • Town Hall
Essex County Board of Taxation	(973) 395-8525	taxboard@admin.essexcountynj.org	465 Dr. Martin Luther King Jr. Blvd, Newark

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